Uncommon Intake

An AI assisted interview, review and career coaching platform for Uncommon.org

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Revised 5 November 2026: the Methodology section now shows the tools used in the final build (React Native with Expo and Supabase Edge Functions instead of Next.js, Netlify and Expo EAS instead of Vercel). The rest of the proposal is unchanged.

1. Problem Statement

What problem am I solving?

Uncommon.org runs a free, 12 month, full time technology bootcamp in Zimbabwe for unemployed young adults. It also runs after school coding classes and teacher training. For many of the young people it serves, the bootcamp is a rare chance.

I am a student at Uncommon.org, so I know how intake works from my own experience. An applicant writes a motivational letter and an application letter, then submits them in person or online. Uncommon's new website already has an online application form for the 2027 bootcamp, with uploads in PDF or Word and help at its hubs, so applying is not the gap. The gap is what comes next.

Staff contact the applicant for an interview by WhatsApp, email or phone call. This causes three problems. Not everyone is free at the moment the call comes, and a person who misses it, or has no data or signal at that time, can lose their chance. Staff have to deal with many separate messages and keep track of who has done what. And there is no standard record of each applicant's letters and answers that a team can review together.

Staff also lack a simple overview. It is hard to see in one place how many people applied, how many places are left, which graduates found jobs, and what students said in the surveys that instructors send them. This information matters for reports to donors and for improving the programme.

There is another gap after a student is accepted. The bootcamp teaches CV writing, cover letters and professional communication, but practising a job interview needs another person's time. Students who have nobody to practise with can walk into their first interviews unprepared.

Who is affected?

Young applicants are affected most, especially those with little data, a poor connection or a shared phone. Uncommon staff and instructors are affected because sorting applicants by hand takes time away from teaching. The organisation is affected too, because its mission depends on choosing fairly and on its graduates finding work.

Why is it important to solve?

A missed phone call should not decide a young person's future. A clear, fair process gives every applicant the same chance to be heard, at a time and in a way that suits them. It also saves staff hours in every intake. Better interview practice helps graduates turn their training into jobs, which is the outcome the whole programme is built for.

2. Proposed Solution

I will build Uncommon Intake (working name), a full stack application with three parts. It is designed to work beside Uncommon's own website and application form and not to replace them. The first part handles interviews and review after someone applies. The second part is a career coach for students. The third part is an overview for staff.

Part one: Interview and review

1. Applicant account. Staff add the applicant, who gets a link by WhatsApp or email. Applicants who applied on Uncommon's form do not fill it in again.

2. Letter feedback. Before submitting to Uncommon, the applicant can paste or upload a motivational or application letter. The AI points out gaps, such as a missing reason for applying or a very short letter. It does not write the letter.

3. Interview in the app. The app shows five fixed questions. The applicant answers each one by typing, recording audio or recording a short video, whichever suits them, and can do it at any time before the deadline.

4. Low data mode. Text and audio come first. Video is optional and has a time limit. An answer recorded without signal is saved on the phone and sent when a connection returns.

5. Hub assisted mode. Hub staff can open the app for a walk in applicant who has no phone or data and let them do the interview on a shared computer.

6. Staff dashboard. Staff see every applicant in one list, with the letters, the written out interview answers and a short summary of each answer. Staff add notes and make the decision.

7. Applicant status page. The applicant can see whether the application was received, whether the interview is done and what the decision is, in simple words. It also shows how to ask for a person to review their application.

Part two: Career Coach

1. CV and cover letter feedback. A student uploads or writes a CV or cover letter and gets clear, simple suggestions.

2. Job interview practice. The student answers common job interview questions and gets feedback on each answer. This reuses the same recording and answer tool built for intake.

3. Progress history. The student can look back at earlier attempts and see how they improved.

Part three: Staff overview

1. Intake numbers. How many applied, were interviewed and accepted for each cohort or hub, and how many places are left.

2. Job outcomes. Staff record which graduates found work, and the page shows the totals.

3. Student surveys. Students answer the short surveys that instructors send them. The AI groups the answers into main themes. Staff can always read every answer.

How AI will be used

• **Letter feedback.** The AI checks a letter against a short list of points the staff care about and returns simple suggestions.

• **Speech to text.** Audio and video answers are turned into text, so staff can read them quickly and applicants without good audio can be understood.

• **Answer summaries.** The AI writes a short summary of each answer and shows how it relates to the points staff are looking for.

• **Career coaching.** The AI gives feedback on CVs, cover letters and practice interview answers.

• **Survey themes.** The AI summarises survey answers into main themes for staff.

People make every decision. The AI never accepts or rejects anyone. Staff can always read the full text of every answer, not only the summary. This keeps the process fair and keeps a person responsible for the outcome.

3. Research Gap

What solutions exist today?

An organisation like Uncommon could handle intake in five ways. The first is what it uses now: letters submitted in person or online, then messages and calls. Its new website adds an online application form, which I checked, but I found no interview, letter feedback or staff review tools. The second is a general form tool such as Google Forms combined with email. The third is an applicant tracking system, the kind companies use to manage hiring. The fourth is a video interview platform built for recruiters.

What are their limits?

Existing option	Limitation for a training programme like Uncommon
Letters, messages and calls	Applicants who miss a call can lose their place. Staff track people by memory and chat history. There is no shared record.
Uncommon's online application form	It collects the application well and hubs help people fill it in. It does not cover the interview, feedback on letters, staff review or the numbers staff need.
General form tools and email	They collect answers, but they do not help staff review them, and they offer no interview or feedback for the applicant.
Applicant tracking systems	Built for companies hiring staff. They can be costly for a nonprofit, and they are not designed around low data users.
Video interview platforms	Usually assume good internet and a decent device. Heavy video is a problem for people who pay for every megabyte. Some also score people automatically, which raises fairness concerns.

How is my solution different?

Uncommon Intake does not replace Uncommon's application form. It adds the steps after it. It is built for applicants with little data, so text and audio come first, and answers can be saved on the phone until there is signal. A person always decides, and the AI only helps staff read and compare. It covers the full journey with one tool: it helps a person prepare to apply, and later helps the same person prepare for a job. It also gives staff an overview of intakes, jobs and survey answers. It also gives the applicant something back, namely feedback on their letters, instead of only collecting information. It is simple enough for a small team to run without training.

4. Methodology

Technologies and frameworks

Part	Choice	Purpose
App and website (frontend)	React Native with Expo (SDK 57), TypeScript and Expo Router	One codebase for the Android app and the website, so applicants can use a phone app and staff can use a laptop
Server logic (backend)	Supabase Edge Functions (Deno, TypeScript)	All server work and every AI call, so no key is ever in the app
Database, login, storage	Supabase (PostgreSQL with Row Level Security)	Accounts, roles, applications, answers, and safe storage of recordings
Recording	Expo audio and camera on phones, browser recording on the website	Lets applicants record audio or short video in the app or the browser

Part	Choice	Purpose
Scheduled jobs	pg_cron in Supabase	Reminders, weekly updates and deleting old recordings on time
Hosting and release	Netlify for the website, Expo EAS Build and EAS Update for the Android app	A live public link, an installable Android app and updates without reinstalling
Code	Git and GitHub	Source code with daily commits

AI APIs and models

The main provider will be the OpenAI API. I will use its text models, through the Responses API with structured outputs, for letter feedback, answer summaries and career coaching. I will use its speech to text feature to turn audio answers into text. I will also use Hugging Face Inference Providers through its OpenAI compatible endpoint as a cheaper option for testing and as a backup for text tasks. Because the endpoint works with the same code, only the base URL, token and model name need to change. All API keys will be stored on the server as Supabase secrets, never in the app, the browser or GitHub.

Development approach

I will build in five small stages and commit to GitHub every day: the application and letters, the interview and speech to text, the staff dashboard and summaries, the career coach, and finally deployment and documentation. I will test with made up applicants. I will not use any real applicant information unless Uncommon gives permission.

Responsible use of AI

The app follows three firm rules.

1. Low data use. Text and audio first, optional short video, and a time limit on each answer.

2. People decide. The AI never makes the final choice. It only transcribes and summarises. Staff can read every answer in full, and an applicant can ask for a person to review their application.

3. Consent and deletion. A clear permission screen appears before any recording and explains why it is made. Recordings are deleted after a fixed period that Uncommon can set, and I suggest 90 days as a starting point.

Because the AI can be unfair to people with different accents, languages or levels of confidence, it will judge only the words that were said. It will not analyse faces or tone of voice. Applicants will be told clearly how the AI is used. Access will depend on roles, so staff see only what they need.

Assumptions and permission

My description of the current process comes from my own experience as an Uncommon student, together with a check of the public beta website, where I found the online application form but no interview or review tools. Before building, I will ask Uncommon staff which features they would use and for their permission to use the organisation as my case study.

Proposed timeline

Dates	Work
19 to 21 October	Research, this proposal, database design and screen sketches. No building until approval.
22 to 24 October	Project setup, GitHub repository, login and roles, staff adding applicants, and letter feedback.
25 to 28 October	Interview screens, audio and video recording, low data mode, speech to text.
29 October to 1 November	Staff review board, answer summaries, the career coach and the staff overview with surveys.

Dates	Work
2 to 3 November	Deployment, testing and bug fixes.
4 November	README, AI explanation, responsible AI statement, screenshots and demo video.
5 November	Final check and submission, with one day to spare.

These dates assume approval by 22 October. If approval comes later, the build stages move with it but the final deadline stays fixed. In that case I would finish the staff overview last, because the interview and review features matter most.

5. Business Plan

Target users

The first users are Uncommon.org, its applicants and its students. After that, the app suits any training programme, bootcamp, scholarship fund or youth organisation that runs intakes and wants to prepare people for work. Uncommon's own website says it wants to take its model to other places, which shows there is room to grow.

Value to users

Applicants get a fair chance that does not depend on a phone call, plus feedback on their letters. Staff save hours in each intake and keep one clear record. Students get free interview practice at any time. The organisation gets a more consistent process and stronger graduates.

Expected costs

Item	Estimate	Note
Development	My own time	Free developer tools and free plans during the build
Hosting and database	Free at first, then about 20 to 50 USD a month	Only if usage grows beyond the free plans
AI usage	A few dollars a month for a few hundred applicants	An estimate. I will measure real cost during testing
Recording storage	Small	Kept low by deleting recordings after the set period
Domain name	About 15 USD a year	Optional

These figures are estimates and I will confirm them when the app is running.

Sustainability and income

Nonprofits cannot pay much, so I do not expect large income from Uncommon itself. I would offer the app free to Uncommon during a pilot, as a real case study. Other training programmes and organisations would pay a small monthly subscription based on the number of applicants per intake, plus an optional setup fee. Organisations can often cover this from grant funding. Because running costs are low, even a modest fee leaves a margin. I would test the price with two or three programmes before fixing it.

6. Conclusion

Young people who apply to Uncommon's bootcamp deserve a process that is fair, simple and light on data. Uncommon Intake gives them useful feedback on their letters and a way to answer interview questions when it suits them. It gives staff a clear list, short summaries, an overview of intakes, jobs and surveys, and full control of the decision. After joining, the career coach helps students practise for the jobs the programme is meant to lead to.

I expect fewer missed chances, less time spent sorting messages, a clearer record of every decision, and better prepared graduates. By 6 November I will deliver a deployed application, a GitHub repository with a

clear commit history, and full documentation that includes the AI explanation and a responsible AI statement. The project solves a real problem for a real organisation, and I can keep developing it after graduation.